

Budweiser is one of America's most iconic brands. And the family behind Budweiser was once one of America's most celebrated success stories. Until recently . . .

In 1860, a German immigrant called Eberhard Anheuser took over the St. Louis brewery that would become Anheuser-Busch. It was on the brink of bankruptcy. Four years later, his son-in-law Adolphus Busch joined him as a business partner. When Anheuser died in 1880, Busch became the company's president.

Busch introduced pasteurization to bottled beer and invested in railroad cars cooled by manufactured ice. His company introduced Budweiser in 1876 and was soon shipping it along St. Louis's extensive network of rail connections. Busch was first to bottle beer on a large scale. This helped make Budweiser America's first national beer.

Adolphus and his wife, Lily, had 13 children. Nine survived to adulthood. The Busch family lived in a Victorian mansion next to the brewery. And they were wildly successful.

When Adolphus traveled, he did so by private railcar, and a cannon blast would announce his return from a long trip. To celebrate their 50th wedding anniversary in 1911, Adolphus and Lily held a party for 13,000 people at the St. Louis Coliseum.¹³

Adolphus looked after his children well, famously giving each of them \$1 million to build a home. His oldest son, August A. Busch, Sr., took over the company upon his father's death in Germany in 1913. August lived at the French-style mansion on Grant's Farm that his father had paid for.

As well as beer, the company made submarine engines in the Great War. In 1920, Prohibition put many of America's breweries out of business. But Anheuser-Busch kept afloat by selling yeast and barley malt syrup for home brewers.

August's son, August A. "Gussie" Busch Jr., said the company survived as the "biggest bootlegging supply house in the United States." This allowed the Busch family to keep their workforce and factory going. And it gave them a jump on the competition when Prohibition ended in 1933.

The company philosophy was "Spend money to make money and make friends." But perhaps the Busch family spent too much money and made too many friends.